

to live in a house for a long period of time to have it retrofitted with a smart lighting solution. But if you plan to rent your home out, you might want to skimp on the smarts and leave it for the tenants.

If you're expanding your current smart lighting system, or have future plans to create an all-encompassing one, you'll have to keep your eye out for the communication protocol you end up using in your smart lighting devices. One of the most common protocols, Z-Wave, is simple and reliable and exclusively a home automation protocol; hence, you will find no dearth of devices using Z-Wave. In a similar vein, ZigBee, another up-and-coming protocol, is a low-power one, that will ensure a long battery life for your devices. However, the issue with Z-Wave, as is with ZigBee, is the need for an external hub to control even a single device running on these protocols. Since your phone can communicate only over WiFi and Bluetooth, even a small and simple automated lighting system might demand the use of an expensive and needless hub to control devices that communicate through Z-Wave and ZigBee. However, if you already plan on purchasing a hub or already have one that is compatible with Z-Wave and/or ZigBee, you can safely purchase devices using these as their sole communication protocols. If your current home is retrofitted with a few devices running on an older X10 system, and you're looking to extend its functionality, you can look to Insteon, which uses the wired X10 protocol and its proprietary Insteon protocol to give you a varied selection of products. The underlying point is that your device's communication protocol should match the protocol YOU intend to use in the future.

Smart switch or smart plug?

The most basic form of lighting automation would be in the form of WiFi controlled light dimmers and switches. The reason we'd call this more basic than a smart lightbulb is because of the cost and convenience involved. So even though a smart lightbulb might allow you to change the colour/hue or play music (we'll review these later, in any case), they can only be controlled remotely, through your phone, tablet or computing device. Though that's very handy if you plan to shut off all your lights at once, you're going to be in a bit of fix if your device is out of charge or simply inaccessible, in which case, the option of being able to manually switch off your lighting should be available to you.

If you zero in on a smart switch, you'll also have to make a decision between a smart plug and smart switch. In-wall switches, like GE's Smart